George Beknazar-Yuzbashev

Postdoctoral Scholar in Economics

Department of Economics, University of Chicago

beknazar@uchicago.edu | www.george.by | (312) 721-3011

RESEARCH FIELDS

Applied Microeconomics; Political Economics; Behavioral Economics.

CURRENT APPOINTMENT

University of Chicago Feb 2026–Present
Postdoctoral Scholar, Department of Economics

EDUCATION

Ph.D. in Economics, Columbia University 2025

M.A. in Social Sciences, Economics Concentration, University of Chicago 2018

LL.M., University of Chicago Law School 2012

Ph.D. in Private Law, Institute of State and Law, Russian Academy of Sciences 2010

Magister Legum (LL.M.), Westfälische Wilhelms-Universität Münster, *magna cum laude* 2006

Diploma of Specialist, Academic Law University, with distinction 2006

JOB MARKET PAPER

Social Media Toxicity and Mental Health

With Francesco Capozza, Kylan Rutherford, and Mateusz Stalinski.

Abstract: Does exposure to social media toxicity, holding platform access constant, affect mental health? We randomly assign participants to a content-level intervention hiding toxic posts and comments on Facebook, X, and Reddit via a browser extension. We observe N = 664 desktop users over a six-week study period in two waves – one during the 2024 US election campaign and one outside of it. Contrary to basic intuition, hiding toxicity worsens mental health. The treatment increases an index of GAD-7 and PHQ-8 symptoms by 0.15σ, and the share of respondents with symptoms above the moderate cutoff rises by 12.1 pp. A QALY-based calibration indicates a welfare cost of about $158 per treated participant. We find evidence consistent with higher loneliness, lower relative moral self-view, and lower exposure to in-group political toxicity as mechanisms. We conclude that curbing toxic content can impose unintended psychological costs, even where it offers other social benefits.

PUBLICATIONS

To the Depths of the Sunk Cost: Experiments Revisiting the Elusive Effect
With Sota Ichiba and Mateusz Stalinski.
Journal of Economic Behavior & Organization 241 (2026): 107352.

Abstract: Despite being often discussed both in practice and academic circles, the sunk cost effect remains empirically elusive. Our model based on reference point dependence suggests that the traditional way of testing it—by assigning discounts—may not produce the desired effect. Motivated by this, we evaluate it across the gain-loss divide in two pre-registered experiments. In an online study with N = 1,806, we randomize the price (low, medium, or high) of a ticket to enter a real-effort task, and observe its effect on play time. Our intervention, which varies the sunk cost by $2 for a 14-minute task, results in a moderate sunk cost effect (0.12 SD or 1.3 min). We further explore the economic applications of the effect in a field experiment on YouTube with N = 11,328 videos in which we randomize whether the time until a pre-video ad becomes skippable is shortened (0 s), default (5 s), or extended (10 s). The intervention has an overall insignificant effect on video engagement. This is driven by a sizable negative effect on the extensive margin, a channel which is not present in the online study. Specifically, more users leave before the video starts in the extended treatment (5.2 pp or 28 % more relative to the shortened treatment). Taking the results of both studies together, we offer evidence of the sunk cost effect in a controlled environment, but its application in policy settings may prove challenging.

A Model of Harmful Yet Engaging Content on Social Media
With Rafael Jiménez-Durán and Mateusz Stalinski.
AEA Papers and Proceedings 114 (2024): 678–83.

Abstract: Why do social media users spend so much time consuming content that seemingly harms them? We build a simple model to argue that advertising-driven platforms can find it profitable to display content that harms users when it is complementary to their time spent on the platform. These incentives disappear, absent network effects, in the case of a subscription-based business model because harmful content reduces the willingness to pay for the platform. Our results warn against interpreting increases in engagement on social media as welfare increases.

Do Social Media Ads Matter for Political Behavior? A Field Experiment
With Mateusz Stalinski.
Journal of Public Economics 214 (2022): 104735.
Discussed in the 2023 *Economic Report of the President*.

Abstract: We exploit Facebook's introduction of a filter hiding ads from the feed as a unique opportunity to study the effects of online ads on political behavior. In a pre-registered experiment, we randomly assigned participants to hide political ads (treatment) or alcohol ads (control) for several weeks preceding the 2020 US elections. We report an insignificant intent-to-treat effect of political ads on turnout (2.3 pp.), but we cannot rule out a sizable positive effect, with 95% confidence interval of $[-2.8, 7.4]$. The result may mask important heterogeneity, with political ads making Democrats slightly more motivated to vote and Republicans – substantially less. We explore the reasons for this effect, such as natural variation in ad content: the majority of Facebook ads on users' feeds skewed Democratic. Lastly, the effect on measures of affective polarization and informedness was negligible.

WORKING PAPERS

Toxic Content and User Engagement on Social Media: Evidence from a Field Experiment
With Rafael Jiménez-Durán, Mateusz Stalinski, and Jesse McCrosky.
Conditionally accepted, *American Economic Review*.

Abstract: Most social media users have encountered toxic content online, but there is scarce evidence of how it impacts engagement. In a pre-registered browser extension field experiment, we randomly hid toxic content on Facebook, Twitter, and YouTube for six weeks. Lowering exposure to toxicity (i) reduced time spent, content consumption, advertising impressions; (ii) reduced the toxicity of user-generated content; and (iii) led to substitution to non-treated social media platforms. A complementary survey experiment shows toxic content triggers users' curiosity, increasing engagement. Taken together, our results suggest that platforms face a trade-off between curbing toxicity and increasing engagement.

Social Media Advertising Loads as Prices
With Rafael Jiménez-Durán, Andrey Simonov, and Mateusz Stalinski.

Abstract: Most social media platforms are funded through advertising rather than direct payments. Why? We argue that three main factors could explain this prevalence: users are more sensitive to monetary prices than to ad loads, microtargeting improves the match quality between users and ads, and platforms can personalize ad loads and thus price discriminate. We conduct a field experiment on Facebook with 1,810 users who install a browser extension that (i) hides nearly all ads or (ii) replaces microtargeted ads with untargeted ones. First, we find that hiding 83% of ads increases time on the platform by only 6%, showing that users are highly insensitive to ad loads. A supplementary study suggests that users are insensitive because they can selectively skip ads. Second, removing targeting sharply reduces ad clicks and long-run engagement, indicating that targeting increases the match quality between users and ads. Finally, roughly two-thirds of ad-load variation occurs across users, consistent with ad-load discrimination. Combining the experimental estimates with a model of user demand, we find that an ad-funded model performs better than a subscription model in terms of profits and consumer surplus. The key mechanisms are that microtargeted ads are engaging and that users are much less sensitive to ad loads than to monetary prices, making advertising a relatively efficient revenue source.

The Prosocial Ranking Challenge: Reducing Polarization on Social Media without Sacrificing Engagement
With Jonathan Stray, Ian Baker, and other coauthors.
arXiv:2603.19626 (2026).

Abstract: We report the first direct comparisons of multiple alternative social media algorithms on multiple platforms on outcomes of societal interest. We used a browser extension to modify which posts were shown to desktop social media users, randomly assigning 9,386 users to a control group or one of five alternative ranking algorithms which simultaneously altered content across three platforms for six months during the US 2024 presidential election. This reduced our preregistered index of affective polarization by an average of 0.03 standard deviations ($p < 0.05$), including a 1.5 degree decrease in differences between the 100 point inparty and outparty feeling thermometers. We saw reductions in active use time for Facebook (-0.37 min/day) and Reddit (-0.2 min/day), but an increase of 0.32 min/day ($p < 0.01$) for X/Twitter. We saw an increase in reports of negative social media experiences but found no effects on well-being, news knowledge, outgroup empathy, perceptions of and support for partisan violence. This implies that bridging content can improve some societal outcomes without necessarily conflicting with the engagement-driven business model of social media.

TEACHING

Columbia University
Teaching Assistant, ECON GU4415: Game Theory (Qingmin Liu) 2021
Teaching Fellow, ECON GU4415: Game Theory (Guillaume Haeringer) Fall 2020

University of Chicago, Harris School Fall 2018
Teaching Assistant to Konstantin Sonin
PPHA 41101: Political Economy I: Introduction to Applied Game Theory

National Research University Higher School of Economics Oct 2012–Jun 2017
External Lecturer, Senior Lecturer, and Associate Professor, Department of Law
Courses taught over multiple years: Economic Analysis of the Law; Public Choice

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

University of Chicago Oct 2018–Jun 2019
Research Professional, Becker Friedman Institute for Economics

University of Chicago May 2018–Jun 2019
Research Assistant to Leonardo Bursztyn, Department of Economics (part-time)

University of Chicago Jul–Sep 2018
Research Assistant to Derek Neal, Department of Economics (part-time)

National Research University Higher School of Economics Sep 2014–Jun 2017
Senior Research Fellow, International Laboratory for Applied Network Research

FELLOWSHIPS AND AWARDS

Summer Department Research Assistant Program funding 2024
(Program for Economic Research)

Economics Department Fellowship 2019–2024

Dean's Fellowship 2019–2020

University of Chicago merit scholarship 2017–2018

Law School Alumni Scholarship Fund, University of Chicago 2011–2012

ACADEMIC SERVICE

Refereeing: AER; QJE; JPE; AEJ: Micro; JPE Micro; JEEA; Journal of Behavioral and Experimental Economics.

Grant reviewing: European Research Council (ERC), Starting Grants. 2025

National Research University Higher School of Economics
Head of the Graduate Program in Law Apr 2014–Jul 2015
Series Managing Editor, Basic Research Program Working Papers in Law Jul 2012–Jul 2015

OTHER PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Georgiev & Partners ZAO: Legal Assistant, Junior Lawyer, and Lawyer 2007–2011

REFERENCES

Leonardo Bursztyn
University of Chicago
bursztyn@uchicago.edu

Andrea Prat
Columbia University
andrea.prat@columbia.edu

Andrey Simonov
Columbia Business School
as5443@gsb.columbia.edu